

Being the Boss in Brussels, Boston, and Beijing

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Session 6 · Reading discussion — leadership across cultures
Based on **Erin Meyer (2017)**, *Harvard Business Review*, July–August
International Summer University^{WU} 2026 · **Dr. Arne Floh**, WU Vienna

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About this reading

- **Source:** Erin Meyer (2017), “Being the Boss in Brussels, Boston, and Beijing,” *Harvard Business Review*, July–August, pp. 70–77 (Reprint R1704D).
- **Author:** professor at INSEAD; author of *The Culture Map* (2014). The article draws on interviews with managers in hundreds of global companies, 2003–2016.
- **The core question:** what does it mean to be a good boss — and a good team member — when leadership norms differ from one country to the next?
- **Why it matters here:** it turns the abstract culture dimensions from our last session into concrete, everyday leadership behaviour.
- **Read it as a manager:** the value is in the four practical playbooks — one for each type of leadership culture.

Learning objectives

- Distinguish the **two dimensions** of leadership culture — attitudes toward **authority** and attitudes toward **decision making**.
- Understand why these two dimensions are **independent**, not two names for the same thing.
- Read the “**four cultures of leadership**” map and locate a country on it.
- Explain the **big “D”** / **small “d”** distinction and the concepts of **nemawashi** and **ringi**.
- Apply the right **leadership playbook** for each quadrant — as a boss and as a follower.
- Connect the framework back to **Hofstede’s power distance** and Hall’s work from the culture session.

The paradox we start with

Americans think of the Japanese as **hierarchical** and of themselves as **egalitarian**. Yet the Japanese often find American bosses **confusing** — even **autocratic**. How can both be true?

The American boss

Outwardly **egalitarian** — first names, open doors, “speak up in meetings.”

But makes the call **alone and fast**: decision power sits with the individual boss. To the Japanese, that looks autocratic.

The Japanese manager

Clearly **hierarchical** — status and rank are respected.

But decisions are **consensual**, built from the bottom up. “I couldn’t adapt from one day to the next — the culture was so contradictory and puzzling.”

The mistake most managers make: treating authority and decision making as if they were one and the same.

Two dimensions of leadership culture

Meyer argues the two most important dimensions of leadership culture must be judged separately.

DIMENSION 1

Attitudes toward authority

How much attention do we pay to a person's **rank or status**, and how much deference do we show it?

Egalitarian ↔ Hierarchical

DIMENSION 2

Attitudes toward decision making

Who calls the shots, and how? Does the **boss decide**, or does the **team decide together**?

Top-down ↔ Consensual

The key move: a country can sit anywhere on one dimension independently of the other.

Dimension 1 — attitudes toward authority



- **Egalitarian:** status differences are played down; it is normal to challenge the boss, skip levels and speak to anyone.
- **Hierarchical:** rank and title command respect; you follow the chain of command and defer to seniority.
- Over the past century, the U.S. and much of Western Europe have shifted toward **empowerment** — first names, open doors, 360° feedback.
- But “pushing authority down” **travels badly** to many emerging markets, where deference to the boss is expected.

This maps closely onto Hofstede’s power-distance dimension from the culture session.

Dimension 2 — attitudes toward decision making



- **Consensual:** decisions are built by the group; slow to reach, but a firm, shared commitment once made.
- **Top-down:** the individual (usually the boss) decides quickly; a decision is provisional and easy to revisit.
- The U.S. dislikes “analysis paralysis” — **any decision is better than no decision**, so power rests with the individual.
- Big “D” cultures such as Germany and Japan prize **getting it right** — no surprise they are two of the great car-making nations.

The key insight: the two are independent

Hierarchy does **not** predict how decisions get made. The most confusing partners are the ones that mix the two.

Country	Authority	Decision making	The surprise
United States	Egalitarian	Top-down	Friendly and informal — but the boss decides alone
Japan	Hierarchical	Consensual	Formal and status-bound — but decisions are collective
Germany	Hierarchical	Consensual	Defers to rank, yet expects to shape the decision
Denmark	Egalitarian	Consensual	Flat and informal — and the group decides together
China	Hierarchical	Top-down	The boss is clearly the director and decides

After Meyer (2017). Positions are broad tendencies, not stereotypes about individuals.

Case 1 — “Chill Factor” enters China

TOP-DOWN + HIERARCHICAL · A U.S.–CHINA JOINT VENTURE

A U.S. firm spent 15 years training staff in **egalitarian methods** — flat structure, open doors, show initiative, set your own objectives. Then it opened a joint venture in Hangzhou, China.

What the Americans saw

“Our Chinese staff show **no initiative** — they wait to be told what to do.”

What the Chinese saw

“It is **not my job** to have my boss’s job. A capable boss **directs** — this one seems not to know what to do.”

Lesson: the egalitarian playbook is not universally “best practice.” Chill Factor had to **pull back** and lead more directly.

Big “D” vs. small “d” decisions

The same word — “decision” — means different things. This is the single most common cross-cultural misunderstanding in the article.

	Big “D” — consensual	small “d” — top-down
Who decides	The group, from the bottom up	The individual boss
Speed	Slow — many meetings first	Fast — “any decision beats none”
Status of a decision	A firm commitment to march forward	An agreement to keep discussing
Changing it later	Hard — reopening feels like breaking a promise	Easy — expected to flex as new data arrives
Typical of	Germany, Japan, the Nordics	United States

Meyer (2017). “If groups have different systems for reaching decisions, you must be explicit about the process.”

Case 2 — Suntory & Beam: nemawashi and ringi

SENSUAL + HIERARCHICAL · A JAPANESE FIRM ACQUIRES A U.S. BUSINESS

Nemawashi

Speaking with each stakeholder **before** the meeting to shape the decision and build agreement in advance.

Ringi

Passing a proposal **level by level**, bottom to top, each layer agreeing before it rises to the next.

The American manager's shock

“I prepared slides to **influence the director** in the meeting. But it was clear the group had **already decided** beforehand — and it differed from my proposal. Trying to convince people **during** the meeting had **no effect at all**.”

Lesson: in a big “D” culture the real decision happens **before** the meeting — so that is where you must do your influencing.

Case 3 — what does “decision” mean?

A GERMAN–AMERICAN PROJECT TEAM

For the Germans

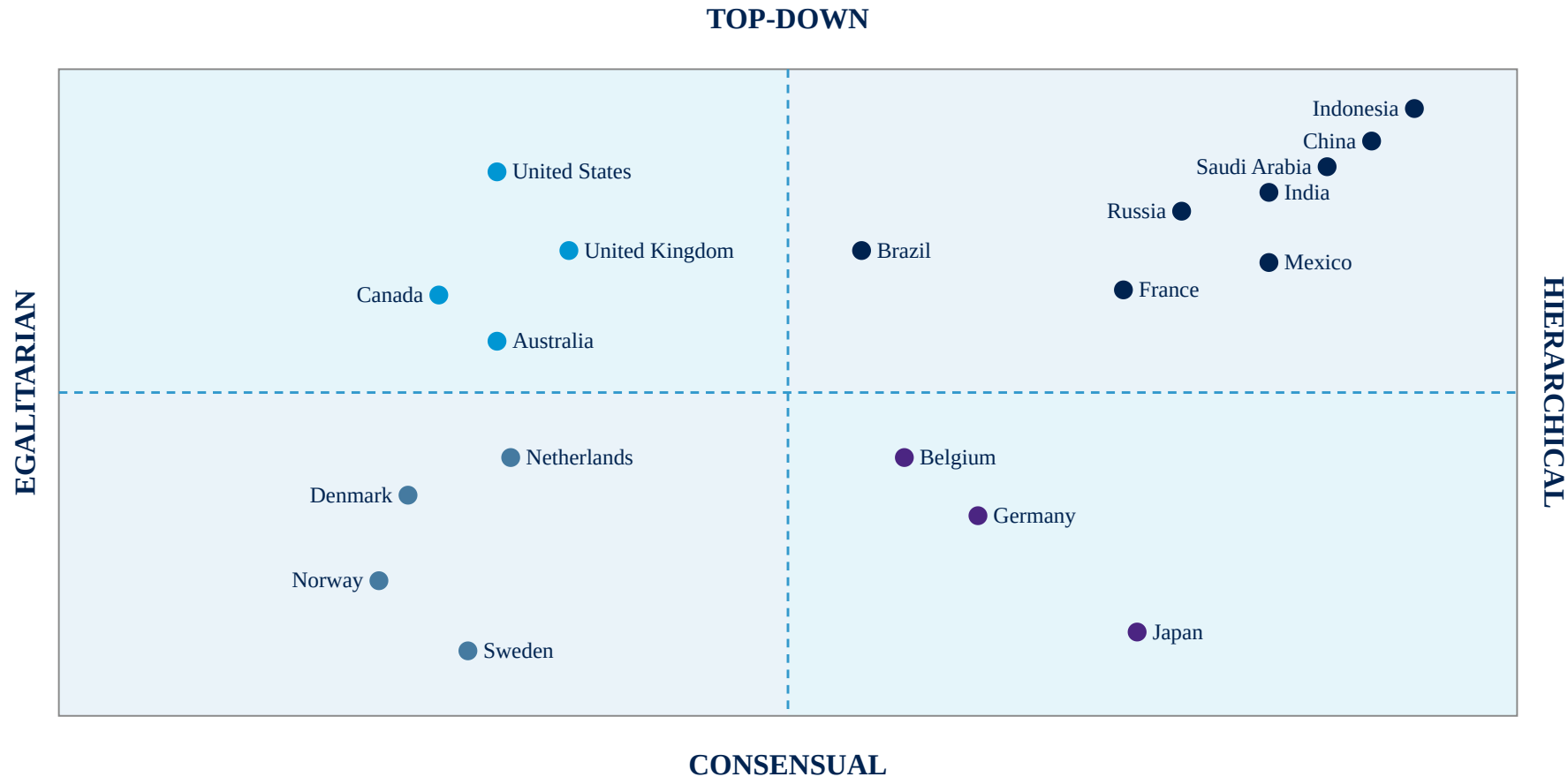
“When you say ‘**we will do this,**’ it is a **promise**. You can’t change your mind casually tomorrow.” They spent days on implementation — then a U.S. colleague casually announced a new direction.

For the Americans

A decision is “simply an **agreement to continue discussions**.” New data? Change course. The Germans read this as **two-faced**; the Americans read the Germans as **inflexible**.

The fix: name it out loud — “Decision with a small ‘d’ — don’t start building yet.” Making the process explicit got the team unstuck.

The four cultures of leadership



Positions of 19 countries from Meyer (2017), based on interviews 2003–2016. Two independent axes create four leadership quadrants.

Consensual + egalitarian

THE BOSS IS A FACILITATOR, NOT THE DECIDER

Denmark

Netherlands

Norway

Sweden

- Expect decision making to take longer — more meetings and more correspondence.
- Show patience and commitment, even when diverging opinions lead to long discussions.
- Don't wait for the boss to jump in and decide — the boss **facilitates** the group.
- Resist pushing for a quick resolution: take the time to get it right, because it is hard to change later.

Meyer's own story: as an American on an all-Danish team, she found consensus-by-email “frustratingly time-consuming” at first.

Consensual + hierarchical

DEFER TO THE BOSS — BUT EXPECT TO SHAPE THE DECISION

Belgium

Germany

Japan

- The team defers to the boss, yet **expects to be part of** the decision-making process — actively solicit input.
- Be patient and thorough: invest the time to get each stakeholder on board.
- Once a group decision starts to form, listen especially carefully to dissenting voices.
- Remember: here a decision is a **commitment** that is not easily altered.

A French director at Deutsche Bank decided “the French way” and was told he wasn’t inclusive — Germans wanted more buy-in first.

Top-down + hierarchical

THE BOSS IS THE DIRECTOR, NOT A FACILITATOR

Brazil China France India Indonesia Mexico Russia Saudi Arabia

- If you are the boss, you will be **deferred to** in public and probably in private — don't be shy about how to show respect.
- Be explicit about expectations (e.g. “bring me three options first”) — **old habits die hard**, so reinforce them clearly.
- Be careful what you say: an off-the-cuff idea can be taken as a **decision** — and suddenly a factory is being built.
- This is the Chill Factor quadrant: leading too “flat” here reads as a boss who doesn't know what to do.

Top-down + egalitarian

SPEAK UP FIRST — THEN ALIGN FAST

Australia

Canada

United Kingdom

United States

- **Before** the decision, speak up — whatever your status. Show initiative; make your voice heard even if you disagree with the boss.
- **After** the decision, align quickly and support it — visible disagreement now makes you look difficult to work with.
- Stay flexible afterwards: decisions here are **rarely set in stone** and can be revisited as new data arrives.
- The World Bank manager mistook a deferential Korean hire's silence for a “lack of self-confidence.”

Connecting back to the culture session

- **Authority $\approx$ Hofstede's power distance:** high power-distance countries sit on the hierarchical side; low power-distance countries on the egalitarian side.
- **But decision making is a separate axis** Hofstede does not capture on its own — which is exactly Meyer's contribution.
- **Hall's high-/low-context communication** helps explain nemawashi: much of the real agreement is reached implicitly, before anyone speaks in the room.
- **Culture is learned, therefore learnable** (last session) — Meyer turns that into **four concrete playbooks** you can actually practise.
- **Manager's takeaway:** don't ask "is this culture like mine?" Ask "where does it sit on **each** of the two axes — and how should I adapt?"

Key takeaways

- Judge leadership culture on **two independent axes**: authority (egalitarian ↔ hierarchical) and decision making (top-down ↔ consensual).
- **Hierarchy ≠ who decides**. The U.S. is egalitarian but top-down; Japan is hierarchical but consensual.
- Master the **big “D” / small “d”** distinction — and make the decision process **explicit** across cultures.
- Use the right **quadrant playbook** — as a boss *and* as a follower.
- There is **no single best way** to lead. Effective global leaders deliberately choose which style fits the context — and how far to adapt.

In-class activity: place your MNE on the map

IN-CLASS ACTIVITY • 15 MINUTES • ASSIGNMENT GROUPS

Objective: connect Meyer's framework to the market-entry group assignment you are working on.

- 1 Take the **home country of your chosen MNE** and the **target country** in your region. Place each on the two-axis map.
- 2 Are they in the **same quadrant** or different ones? Which axis creates the bigger gap — authority or decision making?
- 3 Name **one concrete friction** this gap could create for a manager sent from headquarters to lead the entry.
- 4 Using the quadrant playbook, agree **two adaptations** the MNE's leaders should make — and add them to your risk-management analysis.

Be ready to share your map and one adaptation with the class.



DEPARTMENT OF GLOBAL TRADE · WU VIENNA

Dr. Arne Floh

Senior Lecturer in International Marketing
Deputy Program Director MSc Export- and Internationalisation Management

arne.floh@wu.ac.at

Welthandelsplatz 1, 1020 Wien, Austria
www.wu.ac.at

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